

Jet Fighters

The legacy of WWII was a tremendous advance in jet development. Fighters now had to be jet-powered to be competitive, and able to reach supersonic speeds. In the UK there were only a few manufacturers trying to build the aircraft. Meanwhile, US and Soviet fighters were honed in the skies above Korea. As building costs soared, 1950s fighters would remain in service with smaller nations' air forces for decades.



◁ North American F-86A Sabre 1949

Origin USA
Engine 5,200 lb (2,359 kg) thrust General Electric J47-GE-7 turbojet
Top speed 685 mph (1,102 km/h)

The only US swept-wing fighter able to combat the Soviet MiG-15s, the transonic Sabre used research seized from German aerodynamicists after WWII. First flown in 1947, the "A" began service during 1949.



△ North American F-86H Sabre 1953

Origin USA
Engine 5,910 lb (2,681 kg) thrust General Electric J47-GE-27 turbojet
Top speed 693 mph (1,115 km/h)

Progressive development kept the Sabre competitive against updated MiGs. It had an uprated engine, more adaptable wings, a low-altitude bombing system, and provision to carry nuclear weapons.



◁ de Havilland DH112 Venom Mk4 1952

Origin UK
Engine 4,850-5,150 lb (2,200-2,336 kg) thrust de Havilland Ghost 103/105 turbojet
Top speed 640 mph (1,030 km/h)

Developed from the Vampire with a more powerful engine and slimmer wings, the Venom was first built as a single-seat fighter-bomber, then as a two-seat night-fighter; both were successful.



▷ de Havilland DH115 Vampire T11 1952

Origin UK
Engine 3,500 lb (1,588 kg) thrust de Havilland Goblin 35 turbojet
Top speed 548 mph (882 km/h)

Continued development of this successful early jet, first introduced in 1945, brought this two-seat trainer version. The aircraft remained in use until 1966. Total Vampire production was 3,268.



△ Gloster Meteor NF.14 1953

Origin UK
Engine 2 x 3,800 lb (1,723 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Derwent 9 turbojet
Top speed 585 mph (941 km/h)

The Meteor's night-fighter variant was developed from 1950, with longer wings and an extended nose that contained Air Intercept radar. Early versions served in the Suez crisis; this is the final version.



△ Gloster Meteor F Mk8 1949

Origin UK
Engine 2 x 3,500 lb (1,588 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Derwent 8 turbojet
Top speed 616 mph (991 km/h)

The first British jet fighter was built in thousands. A new tail and stretched fuselage came with the definitive F.8, which served with the RAAF in Korea and with many air forces worldwide.